

Flowers [TRIGGER WARNING: EVERYTHING. SOFT HORROR.]

Bang.

Laurence owned a little pad of property near the forest. Nestled between sheets of pine and greenery, it was flat-roofed and two-storied; almost entirely windows such that the house's exposed corners shone in the sun. Jutting alcoves of glass regularly marked the first-floor wall facing the street, and even from there, delicate flower-heads poked through— vases too— in all manner of exotic colours snipped to circular perfection, angles obliterated. Laurence took especially to pastels, no matter the time of year; so indicative of cleanliness, so pure in essence, that any other colour might be an insult to his home's demure creams and understatements.

The house gardener, entrusted with managing the dirtier turns of life (outdoor soil, insects, and even worse, *others*) kept his lawn clipped and a modest, neat selection of native plants near the front door. Blue vervain pushed up and outwards like a struggling tiger; kaffir lilies hid their colour under a veil of shade; pruned shrimp plants played along their boundaries; and showy mums, white as Laurence's wrist, crowned the section— not yet full-grown, teasing at mature beauty.

Bang. Bang. Bang.

He'd fired his previous gardener just two weeks ago in lieu of another, more servile type who did as asked; never planted anything out of turn or said anything out of turn. It was already stressful enough, interacting with dirt become flesh, and the new hire understood this. Understood his place. The world spun much easier when every citizen and thing accepted the fate given to them by— not God, no— by birth and aesthetic science. Circumstance.

As *his* circumstances allowed, Laurence held access to bottomless funds, which he spent exclusively on the expensive upkeep of show-quality flowers. Pink, red, and white begonias graced the first of three glass alcoves, each in an individual, complementarily-coloured vase. He'd imported the porcelain from China and hired an artist to refurbish its illustrations fresh as making-day. Filled to the brim with dark, saturated soil, he spent each morning raking through for dead leaves and contaminants. The occasional fly fell victim to promises of nectar. Being a master gardener, his organic poisons were fully lethal; any living thing divorced from Plantae would suffer paralysis, then die an unimpressive, convulsing death upon contacting the vase rims.

Bang. Scrape. Bang.

The second alcove, in order of closeness to the front door, contained speckled, multicoloured orchids bunched in bloom as if to mimic alveoli, living and breathing and globular, dipped in complex scent— a light, flowery wash at first sense, then something darker and muskier; almost sweet. Like meat gone bad. Polarising as patchouli. Laurence spent almost every morning watching these orchids bend their swanlike necks, shifting just the slightest bit,

tolling in the hours with a human shrug of petals. He spoke to them, as he spoke on this particular day and moved about his routine. Having passed two alcoves, armed with a watering can and jar of fertiliser, he stepped stealthily— which was usual fare, of course, given how he hated to bother the home.

Scrape. Scrape. Scrape.

Laurence was convinced that his walls housed some sort of malevolent spirit. Either that or raccoons, but to confirm he would have to bring the gardener around and purify him. Him and his dirty body, too rough for the carpets over which Laurence drifted. He was a horticulturist, purveyor of preservation, and best of all, curator— and in accordance with this job, avoided all prospective instances of contamination. His orchids were rare, sizes passing from unnoticeable to centrepiece quality, morning light dashed on their array of rainbows like boat to siren-made shore, varieties the amateur could not even dream of; genetically modified variants shipped from China, Rothschild's Slippers in all their haughtiness, delightful Paphiopedilum with pale pink slipper-toes; even stranger, extinct shadows peeking from the third alcove.

Bang. Bang. Bang.

Rolling up his sleeves, Laurence unscrewed the fertiliser jar's cap, nose wrinkling just the slightest bit. He would never grow accustomed to the organic smell of it. Better than cow dung, with a sharper edge, and many more dimensions, but most definitely an acquired taste. He lived near the forest, yet his sensibilities were quite proper; suited to the high society he had long since left. Old habits never died, even when cast aside in pursuit of flowers and chemically perfect fertiliser.

Regular gardeners— the sort he'd met on regretful trips to the outside— were quite convinced that little pebbles of potassium would suffice. Their plants were thus made dull, drooping like neglected children; so unlike his prim, proper, *trained* creations. He took into account the second dimension of botanical need and understood why growth progressed the way it did, noting each step in the carefully-planned cycle of photosynthesis. Flowers needed holistic care. Beneficial microorganisms and fertiliser of substance. Real, semi-solid substance; none of that compost business touted as organic. If the food sold to humans was half-plastic, what could be said of the food sold to plants? Not much. The real purifier of all things, ripened fruit— he scoured the mush with his fingers, raising a small, brownish clump to eye level.

Bang. Bang.

This was clean. Cleaner than whatever the amateurs suggested, for he'd prepared it specially; engaged in an ageing process that severed the source from its usual comfort, introduced preservatives and other compounds of that nature, and ensured periods of anoxicity for proper separation such that when the time came, he would be able to harvest his share and dispose of the unwanted bits. Ordinarily, about a month was necessary for complete maturity, at which

point nutrient release was its highest, indicated by a horrid smell but obvious readiness in form and texture; almost pull-off-the-source tender.

Humming and only a bit miffed by the pests, Laurence tipped clumps of fertiliser into the third alcove's vases, sinking his thin white hand into the soil, skin and dirt all one. He would be a sore liar if he said he did not enjoy the cleanliness of the process. His plants were watered to perfection, indicated by the soil's granularity, and each variable— temperature, humidity, volume of fertiliser— had been under control since they'd entered the home. They commanded sterility, even over him.

Bang. Crash.

It was better that others did not meddle with his craft. The last gardener, who he deigned to forget but could not help remembering at times like these, was a skinny sort of fellow with unbrushed hair and a good nose; always poking around, asking why he couldn't take a look at the flowers indoors, for they were obviously much prettier than the basic scrub encircling the home, but Laurence was firm in his denial. Firm enough that he'd backed away for quite some time. There was also, of course, the issue of relatives asking to visit, and stranger, more commanding individuals who never found what they intended, and sometimes solicitors, though he admitted them when needed, for human presence was paramount to proper fertiliser growth.

The plants *did* love prospective friends, though they accepted him alone. While their wants and his catering seemed hypocritical— dirty people, sullied outdoor world, all necessary for Laurence's ultimate goals yet counter to them— he accepted his hypocrisy and worked around it. He avoided direct contact, administering only enough to sustain the plants and fertiliser. He kept them happy, as children were made soft with toys and candy. Sometimes he played them music. Other times...

*Crash. Crash. **Crash.***

The rapture that so often took him during his weekly romps of intensive care was strong, but not enough to dull instinct. No gardener worth his salt would let pests of any type invade his home, nonetheless destroy its walls with incessant scratching. Carefully, Lawrence screwed the lid onto the fertiliser jar, brushed bits of soil on top of the affected orchid so as to appear neat again, and stowed the jar underneath his sill, where even the longest peering neck might not reach. He rose slowly, as if taking a test of etiquette, and unfolded, passing without sound— but ardent still— through the open space that was his drawing room over to a small, tucked-away side door that led to an undercroft. Ears sharp, he knew that this was the source, and skittered off to the kitchen, retrieving a metal pipe in case something large (rattish or racoonish, perhaps even rabid) attacked him. While his build was small, silks draping his back in the old fashion of the day, he was adept. Almost made to wield it.

*Bang. Bang. **Bang.***

The door, smooth with cream-coloured varnish, creaked open. Almost immediately a horrid smell, a rot that laid asleep beneath his clothing, seldom peeking through the perfume of flowers, slapped him across the face. Never would he fully acclimate to the shock of entering a different world, and he was not a magician by trade. Perhaps he was meant to keep all the world's beautiful and clean things on his ark, once again absent of magic but obviously blessed in some way. This, then, was the chosen human sample. Useless as a whole. Useful in parts. Divinity smiled upon him.

Wail.

Brow furrowed, Laurence stepped back from his unfinished work— fertiliser not yet ripe for the picking, more dangerous than useful— waves of acidic putrescence clinging to him like starved hands. Sprawled across the stairs, wriggling and thumping its bloodied head all over the carpeting, was a caterpillar robbed of its limbs, save for one half-severed, gangrenous stump that smelled thickly of sulphur and iron. Nutrition. The head of this caterpillar appeared human, and very well may have been human, now home for maggots swirling among its cavities; poking out from the eyes, mouth, and ears almost playfully, making use of the rottenness, leaving blackened bits in their wake. Still thumping. Still trying its best to escape, the caterpillar inched forth to no avail. The last step, slightly higher than the rest, was insurmountable. Behind trailed ribbons of faeces and urine, zigzagging paths where the pitiful creature's bladder gave way, mapping its path.

Wail.

Upon raising its head to meet Laurence, the caterpillar screamed again. There was an obviously human quality to its voice; the characteristic gargle of burnt vocal folds. Writhing, angry lines pulsed from its forehead and half-rotten neck, either maggots consuming it from the inside, worms, true veins, or a soupy mess of all three, and the screams continued, on and on like sirens, until Laurence felt he needed to put a stop to them. It would be a terrible inconvenience, see, if the neighbours came and visited again, casseroles in tow, and faced him in such a state. Fertiliser was exceedingly difficult to scrape from the mind— settling thickly, clogging the lungs, conflated with all other sorts of organic matter— and even an idiot would smell the freshness of it.

Surprising, though. *Impressive*, even. How the human body could withstand all sorts of bizarre trauma; amputation, abduction, assault in any way that mattered, and keep on living. If Laurence appreciated one thing about their initial dirtiness, it was the artistry. Being a cobbled-together, faulty machine, yet so hellbent on fighting until the bitter end. No god would ever settle for such selfishness. Men (caterpillars) of strong will such as this were ideal. Within them lay a treasure trove, each ingredient marinated to culmination.

But this one was not yet ready. Its ragged breaths indicated life, and a steady flow at that. Perhaps whatever spirit remained might summon enough energy for another escape. Laurence could not afford escape, though watching the thing slither around *would* be great entertainment for his flowers. He thumbed his pipe and thought.

Choke.

As mentioned, he was not the sort who enjoyed company. His last gardener had been something of an exception before overstepping their boundaries; tracking dirt into the home, breathing the same air as him and his flowers; letting cold air in such that the household temperature lowered by two degrees exactly. The man was not armed, but put up a great fight, and Laurence gave the orchids quite a scare, for his body fell underneath them, lids fluttering shut under curious, downturned heads. Three purple petals fell atop his forehead like a funeral shroud. Later he woke, as customary, and the fertilisation process began. It was difficult with all his talkativeness, pleading mutual love for flowers and all things beautiful and how this was so very out of the contrary— oh, he thought Laurence was a gentleman. He loved him. He needed him.

Correcting his misdemeanours, Laurence reminded him that he was not made to be needed, and he did not need anything but his flowers. The rest of the world was for show, and as for ‘all things beautiful’, he spoke of how his processes were only a slight departure from conventionality. Soon enough, the gardener quieted. But he hadn’t yet broken.

Thump.

Leaning down, drinking from the sour spring of decomposition, Laurence shook his head. He grimaced, never truly used to it. Then, despising the inkblot among the creams and flatness of his little pad, he brought the pipe down upon the caterpillar’s head. The thing gave a defeated squeak, and soon the heel of his boot thumped against its side— squelching, tearfully begging in a shrunken brain’s tongue, all the way down the stairs. Below was utter blackness, and what remained of it soon disappeared, eaten by impossibility as a fly to a snap trap.

Laurence spent the rest of his day, sunny and pleasant, scrubbing the stink raw from his skin and mixing wood chips into orchid potting soil. Orchids were epiphytes, meaning that ordinarily, in the dirty wild, they grew on trees. They could not survive alone without wooden supports and reliable care. In some undiscovered way, they also sensed intentions— permitting any act so long as it benefited them. Selfish as babies but much, much prettier. And fresher in the sense that they’d grown from the very beginning in a controlled environment chock-full of auxin and conducive hormones. No transference from dirty mothers. It was marvellous, this immaculate conception; all his, the humble guardian.

When he grew tired of maintenance, an inevitable outcome, Laurence peered outside his alcoves and watched the new gardener work. She did well with the hedges and wore no perfume to eclipse the flowers. Overall a diligent, well-bred individual. Before this, she’d undoubtedly been some sort of farmhand; it showed in the sloppy, purposeful heave-ho of her arms; the curve of her tired, slick back simmering in the heat. Laurence enjoyed— in a less perverse, more fascinated manner— her devotion. This time around, he suspected she might actually *enjoy* returning to nature. Some bodies were built for giving back.

He flashed a smile out the window and waved, almost able to picture her eyes socketless, drooling mouth agape; legs twisted and broken. She smiled in kind return.